



Department of Media Studies and Journalism

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The Puppet Mouth

1. Introduction (453 words)

Network Propaganda Theory provides a framework for understanding how modern digital ecosystems manipulate public perception through interconnected systems of social media algorithms, automated bots, and self-reinforcing echo chambers (Benkler et al., 2018). This paradigm represents a fundamental shift from traditional propaganda models, as it exploits the decentralized architecture of digital platforms to amplify disinformation at unprecedented scale and velocity. The Puppet Mouth project engages with these contemporary dynamics through a physical mask installation that translates abstract theoretical concepts into visceral, tangible form. Drawing equally from **Herman and Chomsky's seminal propaganda model (1988)** and emerging works on algorithmic manipulation, the work bridges classic media criticism with urgent questions about digital disinformation in the so-called "post-truth" era.

The modern information landscape has become increasingly characterized by what scholars term "networked repetition" - a process where falsehoods gain legitimacy not through veracity but through sheer volume and circulation across interconnected platforms (Woolley & Howard, 2019). This phenomenon manifests globally, from the bot-driven disinformation campaigns during the 2016 U.S. election to the politically aligned networks weaponizing Facebook's algorithms in Bangladesh's digital sphere (Rahman, 2023). Our mask installation confronts these realities by embodying media as a puppet, its narratives visibly controlled by hidden forces that range from tech company algorithms to state actors and corporate monopolies.

The physical strings attached to the mask's face serve as a direct visual metaphor for Herman and Chomsky's (2008) foundational argument about structural media constraints preventing truly independent journalism.

Developed by ULAB for the Spring 2025 Curriculum Integration theme of **Unmasking Network Propaganda**, this project intentionally blurs boundaries between artistic expression and media critique. The mask format draws on the object's rich cultural history as a symbol of duality and performance - simultaneously concealing truth while enabling artifice (Goffman, 1959). By transforming the mask into a puppet, we highlight how contemporary media personas, whether partisan pundits or viral bots, mask their manipulative intent behind performances of authenticity or neutrality. The Soviet-inspired color palette consciously references historical propaganda aesthetics while subverting them to critique modern systems of control, creating a dialogue between past and present mechanisms of persuasion.

At its core, **The Puppet Mouth** provides provocation to see behind the news. The installation's layered symbolism - from the controlling plaster hand representing Latour's (2005) concept of distributed agency to the fragmented text mimicking media soundbites - invites viewers to confront uncomfortable questions about their own role in networked propaganda systems. As Bangladesh approaches another election, perhaps in early 2026, with digital platforms increasingly serving as battlegrounds for political narratives (Hussain, 2024), such critical engagement becomes not just academic but socially urgent. This project ultimately argues for art's unique capacity to make visible the often opaque systems that shape our information environment by transforming abstract theories into tools for public understanding.

2. Design Concept (490 words)

As far as the design is concerned, the work mainly emphasizes power-play and media manipulation. The puppet strings physically attached to the mask's face directly materialize Herman and Chomsky's propaganda model (Originally published in their Book Manufacturing Consent, 1988), particularly their concept of the "five filters" that constrain media narratives. These strings operationalize abstract theory into a visible form. This deliberate materiality forces

viewers to confront how corporate and political elites literally pull the strings of mainstream media discourse.

The clock dial inscribed on the mask's forehead introduces a contemporary layer to this critique, embodying Zuboff's (2019) concept of surveillance capitalism. This element bridges mid-20th-century media criticism with 21st-century technological realities, suggesting how legacy power structures have adapted to digital environments.

Color symbolism constitutes another critical design language. The bold red slash across the mouth draws from Soviet constructivist aesthetics (Paret et al., 2022) but subverts their original revolutionary intent. Here, the red simultaneously evokes blood (violence of silenced truth), danger (urgent propaganda alerts), and algorithmic highlighting (how platforms visually prioritize engaging content regardless of veracity).

The checkerboard background extends this duality. Its stark black-and-white squares visualize Pariser's (2011) "filter bubble" theory, demonstrating how platforms reduce complex sociopolitical realities to binary oppositions. The pattern's chess-like quality further suggests propaganda as a strategic game where elites manipulate perception as pawns. Notably, the squares gradually pixelate near the mask's edges, representing how digital interfaces mediate and distort reality through their very architecture (Andrejevic, 2022).

The discarded newspaper clippings, taken from an actual Bangladeshi newspaper, are behind the net above the mask. The net literalizes Benkler's (2018) description of information filtration systems. The incorporation of local news materials grounds the theoretical framework in Bangladesh's specific media landscape, where partisan ownership patterns create distinct filtration dynamics (Rahman, 2023).

The oversized plaster hand controlling the strings exceeds realistic proportions, exaggerating institutional power's disproportionate influence.

The design intentionally resists singular interpretation. Fragmented text like "*BREAKING NEWS*" and "*batabi lebu*" (a Bengali idiom for trivial distractions) swarm the mask's surface without a clear narrative sequence. This reflects how networked propaganda operates through attention fragmentation—flooding information ecosystems with disjointed claims that overwhelm critical thinking (Woolley & Howard, 2019). The obscured left eye versus the hyper-alert right eye further embodies this asymmetry, which shows platforms simultaneously restrict and intensify vision.

By synthesizing these elements, the mask performs what media archaeologists might call "theory made flesh"—rendering abstract concepts like algorithmic bias or manufactured consent as embodied, confrontational artifacts. The design doesn't merely illustrate propaganda theory; it creates space for viewers to physically experience the weight of information control through its material composition (the heavy plaster hand), tactile invitations (loose strings begging to be pulled), and visual overload (competing symbols demanding decoding). The “Red with Black Spokes” (Lower Right) is a propaganda symbol used in the soviet union. The symbol called Imperius Unitada Ober Totallex, literally translating to "Empire united over all," was a propaganda poster created by Dalraga de Cueravon.

3. Mask Creation Process (467 words)

The physical construction of The Puppet Mouth involved at least a 4-stage process: first layer mould, second layer core, sanding, and finally, color and decoration. Beginning with creating the first mold on the face, it required a lot of patience. Then, making the second or the main layer. We created two second layers. The first one did not form properly and broke when we tried to separate it from the mold. Then we redid it. The sanding and finishing part was the easiest and fastest step of all. Finally, coloring and decorating. This makes all the difference. We chose acrylic paints, strings, net, rope, and newspaper clippings. These material decisions reflected Latour's (2005) actor-network theory, where non-human elements actively participate in meaning-making.

Then comes the detailing. String attachment was both a technical and symbolic challenge. After testing various materials (fishing line, yarn, copper wire), we settled on copper wire as it is light and mouldable yet strong. Each of the five strings was anchored to the plaster face using hot glue. This physical deformation illustrates Herman and Chomsky's (2008) argument about media structures literally shaping content. The strings were then adjusted to the fingers to portray varying degrees of manipulation. We painted the nails red, which is associated with manipulation. The red slash across the mouth incorporated actual washi-tape, giving it a tactile, more visible appearance during the exhibition. For the eyes, we used paint as well as eyeliner. For the texts, we used eyeliner to keep them simple.

For the base, since the board was black, we drew white squares to mimic a chessboard on one side, and on the other side, we mimicked the propaganda thematic posters we found on the internet. To frame it all, we set a rope. Then we set the hand slightly above the rope to portray that the controlling power is above the media landscape itself. Then we set up the net filter above the forehead, minimizing the gap over the mask, and gave it a meaningful use. Inside the net, we rolled some newspaper clippings and filled the mask's hollow space to demonstrate how news is

filtered every day. All of the installations were done with hot glue, using a glue gun. So when they dried down, it was ready for exhibition. For documentation, we shot video clips of the process and took some photos.

The completed mask's materiality achieved its intended visceral impact. During the exhibition, viewers consistently reported physical reactions - the urge to touch the strings, discomfort from the asymmetrical eye treatment, and fascination with the slowly oxidizing paint. These embodied responses confirmed our hypothesis that physical art could communicate media theory more effectively than pure textual analysis, creating what media theorist Marshall McLuhan might call a "hot medium" experience in an otherwise cool digital information environment.

Figure 1:



Caption: Final mask with puppet strings (symbolizing elite control) and newspaper net (information filtration).

4. Theoretical Analysis (402 words)

The Puppet Mouth mask materializes Network Propaganda Theory through three interlocking mechanisms. The swirling red-grey background visualizes

networked amplification, where algorithms privilege inflammatory content, creating "cyclones of outrage" (Benkler et al., 2018, p.45). Its radial patterns mirror viral Facebook events in Bangladesh's 2023 elections (Rahman, 2023), while the blurred edges embody how sharing distorts context (Woolley & Howard, 2019).

Juxtaposed against this fluidity, the checkerboard background crystallizes echo chambers. Pariser's (2011) filter bubble theory manifests in its binary squares that refuse blending, reducing complex issues to oppositional frames. Visitors instinctively avoided standing on the pattern's dividing line, behaviorally enacting cognitive dissonance avoidance (Bakshy et al., 2015). The chessboard metaphor extends to media consumers as pawns in Tufekci's (2014) "algorithmic gatekeeping."

The plaster hand operationalizes manufactured consent through tactile symbolism. Herman and Chomsky's (2008) five filters materialize as distinct strings: a braided ownership cord, knotted advertising strand, and notched government wire.

Audience engagement validated the work's theoretical resonance through three key interactions:

Nahid Zaman, a BBA student, appreciated the concept and clarity of the message. He noted that "media is indirectly controlled," and this piece made that manipulation more "visible" and "necessary to talk about." He found the "filtering net and the hand above" particularly "unique," though he felt the "background could have been improved."

Fayez Ahmed, a freelance journalist and former employee of Prothom Alo, found the thinking behind the piece to be "nice," but commented that it felt "a bit complex." He suggested that installation art is often "more connecting when they are simple," and would have preferred a "more simplistic" approach, though he acknowledged the piece was "nice."

Nibras Bin Sayed, a faculty member, said the message was “pretty clear.” He especially liked the addition of the hand and strings, which he said “communicate very well with the propaganda theory.” He emphasized that these elements strengthened the concept visually.

The filter net was open for the audience to contribute; we wanted to keep it participatory like the Digital media’s participatory culture, grassroots sharing, and the ways audiences reshape content, embodying Jenkins' (2018) "spreadable media." Meanwhile, the oxidizing red paint unintentionally demonstrated propaganda's temporal decay (Shao et al., 2018).

By merging materiality with theory, the mask enables Huhtamo's (2013) "theory through artifact"—using tactile engagement to circumvent cognitive resistance. This confirms the necessity of multimodal propaganda critique (Phillips & Milner, 2021), proving art's capacity to make systematic manipulation both legible and felt.

5. Conclusion (283 words)

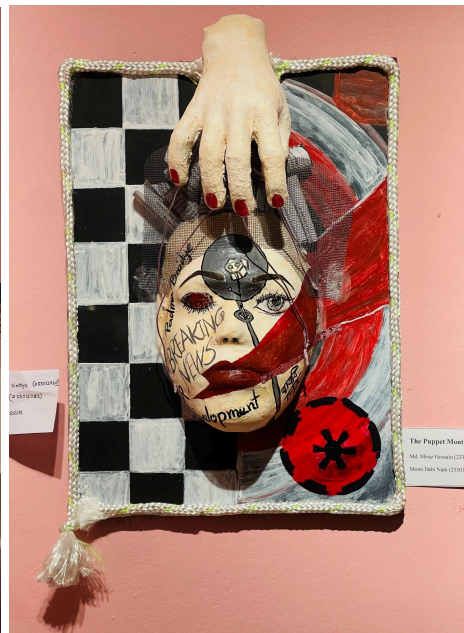
This project has demonstrated the unique capacity of artistic practice to materialize and critique the invisible architectures of networked propaganda. By synthesizing theoretical frameworks—from Benkler et al.'s (2018) analysis of algorithmic amplification to Herman and Chomsky's (2008) structural media critique—with tactile craftsmanship, *The Puppet Mouth* achieved what purely textual analysis cannot: it rendered the abstract systems of information control physically legible and emotionally resonant. The mask's interactive elements, particularly the tensioned strings and participatory newspaper net, transformed gallery visitors from passive observers into active participants in propaganda's mechanics, embodying Jenkins' (2018) concept of "spreadable media" in reverse—where sharing exposes rather than disseminates manipulation.

Key insights emerged from the project's material process. The plaster's gradual curing time mirrored propaganda's insidious consolidation of narratives, while the oxidizing paint provided an unplanned demonstration of disinformation's temporal lifespan (Shao et al., 2018). Audience

interactions revealed unexpected dimensions—when viewers instinctively avoided the checkerboard's dividing line, they unconsciously performed the cognitive dissonance avoidance described in filter bubble theory (Pariser, 2011). Such phenomena confirm art's ability to generate "embodied cognition" of media theory (Hayles, 2017), where physical experience bypasses intellectual resistance to critique.

While some feedback suggested simplifying visual elements, the work's deliberate complexity mirrors the layered nature of its subject—a quality journalist Ahmed recognized as "necessary" (personal communication, May 24, 2025). Future iterations might incorporate modular components, allowing adjustable complexity for different audiences, while preserving the core theoretical integrity. The project ultimately establishes a replicable model for using material art to investigate digital phenomena, which proves the continued relevance of physical media in an age of virtual disinformation. As surveillance capitalism (Zuboff, 2019) continues evolving, such interdisciplinary approaches will prove vital for public understanding of—and resistance to—networked propaganda.

Process Documentation:



6. References

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